Abstract

Designing and Piloting a Systematic Student Managed Investment Fund: The UWA Red and White Fund.

Students at regional institutions like UWA often have limited or no exposure to the sophisticated trading strategies now standard across the financial industry, which can restrict recruitment opportunities. This project asks: can a student-built programmatic trading environment give UWA finance students practical, career-relevant experience in systematic investing? Over twelve months, I will build and pilot the simulated trading branch of the UWA Red and White Fund, a student-managed portfolio in the College of Business, intending to establish a live funded branch once performance is proven. Guided by my faculty mentor, Dr. Nezha Hamoutan, I will develop a simulated trading platform linked to market data, then teach a team of student investors to write scripts that screen securities, backtest strategies, and place orders automatically. Trades will be checked in code against the fund's Investment Policy limits, and returns measured against benchmarks. Compliance and performance will be audited regularly. Expected outcomes include a tested platform, reusable strategy and backtesting code, and a performance and compliance report. Over 400 student-managed funds are documented in North America. Research on similar programs at other universities find that participating finance graduates achieve significantly higher placement rates and starting pay than finance graduates outside the program. Such programs also often attract institutional partnerships from large firms. A pilot like this could strengthen UWA's recruitment, student placement, and alumni engagement. Grant funds, if allocated would cover hosting, data access, and infrastructure costs.